A ONE-VARIABLE DEEP DIVE · TRUSTMRR DATASET

Free Trials Are Fine. Freemium Is a Trap.

What 657 startups' actual pricing pages reveal about which monetization model wins — and which one everyone defaults to anyway.

Source: TrustMRR dataset, frozen 30 Jul 2026 · pricing_model field, original classification

One Free-Text Field, Seven Pricing Strategies

TrustMRR captures each startup's actual pricing copy verbatim — not a category. 657 of 1,000 startups have this field filled in. To analyze it, each entry was classified into one dominant pricing strategy based on its language and structure.

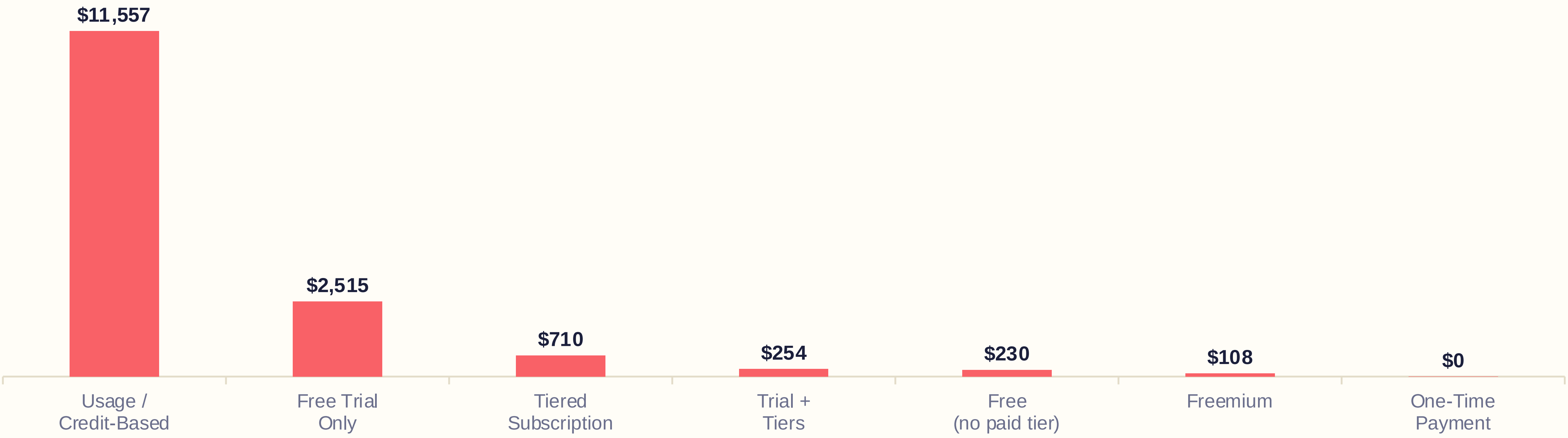
Usage/Credit-Based	*"Universal Credit System: Pay only for what you use"*
Freemium	*"Free: 5 reports/month, Pro: $15/mo, Pro+: $39/mo"*
Tiered Subscription	*"Starter $19.99/mo, Pro $39.99/mo, Business $59.99/mo"*

Classification logic: presence of usage/credit language, trial mentions, one-time/lifetime pricing, and count of distinct price points (2+ = tiered). Full taxonomy: Usage-Based, Free Trial Only, Free Trial + Tiers, Tiered Subscription, Freemium, Free (no paid tier), One-Time Payment.

FINDING 01 · THE STANDOUT

Usage-Based Pricing Crushes Every Alternative

Median MRR by pricing strategy, across 569 classified startups. Median (not average) is used so a few huge outliers don't distort the comparison.



Usage-based startups post a median of **$11,557 MRR** — 16x the next-best model and over 100x plain Freemium.

FINDING 02 · THE CONTRADICTION

Freemium Is the Most Popular — and Weakest — Choice

MOST COMMON STRATEGY

162

startups use Freemium — more than any other classified pricing strategy

BUT ITS MEDIAN MRR IS

$108

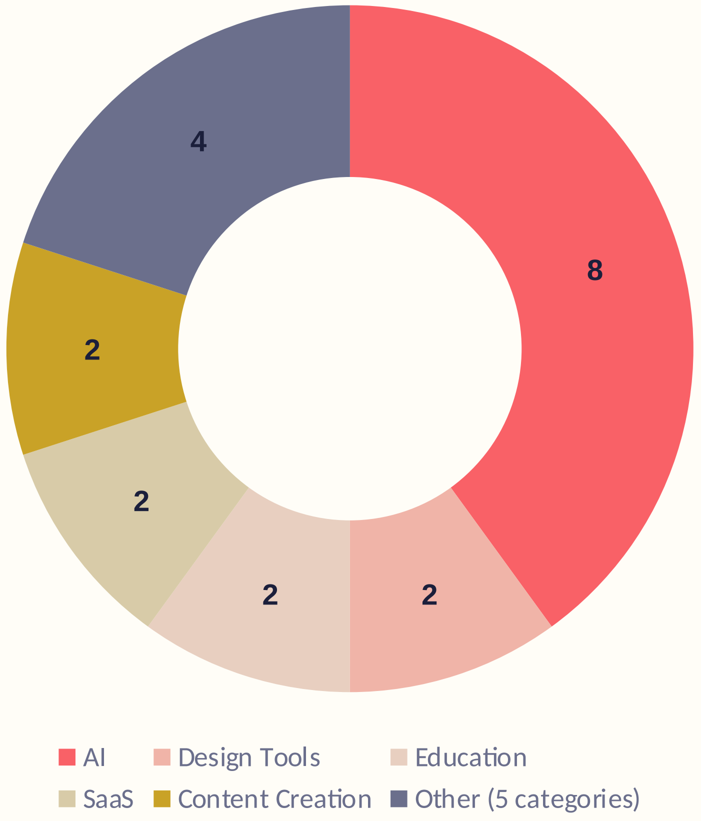
— the lowest of any strategy with a paid tier at all

Why the gap is real, not random

- Free tiers set an anchor of $0 — converting a user off that anchor is a much harder ask than metering usage from day one.
- Freemium is concentrated in crowded, low-friction categories — 37 of 162 are AI tools, where free alternatives are one tab away.
- Usage-based pricing ties revenue directly to value delivered — power users simply pay more, with no conversion event required.

The Usage-Based Edge Isn't an AI Artifact

The 20 usage-based startups span 9 categories — AI is the largest single slice, but the model shows up in Design Tools, Recruiting, Real Estate, and more.



50 / 50

B2B / B2C split among usage-based startups — the model works on both sides, not just enterprise API buyers

Top performers by name

1Lookup (fraud-check API) — $207K MRR
ChatDash (AI usage billing) — $38.6K MRR
Capgo (dev tools) — $24.4K MRR
Sleek (design tools) — $22.2K MRR

THE TAKEAWAY

Meter Value, Don't Give It Away

If you're choosing a pricing model for a new SaaS product, this dataset argues for one clear default.

01 **Usage-based wins by a mile.**

Median $11,557 MRR — 16x tiered subscriptions, 100x+ Freemium.

02 **Freemium is the default trap.**

Most-used strategy (162 startups), but the weakest earner of any model with a paid tier.

03 **It's not an AI-only effect.**

Usage-based pricing outperforms across 9 categories and both B2B and B2C.

04 **The lesson is structural.**

Metering revenue to value delivered removes the free-to-paid conversion event entirely.

Source: TrustMRR dataset, 569 classified startups, frozen 30 Jul 2026